

CHAPTER 2 — THE COST OF THE FLAME

The search for the Night Stalker finally ended in the southern reaches of Velldengar, at a secluded hut hidden deep within the Dark Forest. Nathanos Thornwell and his squad had followed the trail through blood and snow, but the battle had nearly been lost. When hope seemed to be fading, Raphael Marchand seized the only chance they had: he caught the Night Stalker from behind and held her in place, giving Nathanos the opening to strike.

Nathanos drove his heated blade through the Night Stalker's chest, killing her, but the same blow pierced Raphael and left him gravely wounded. As the mask fell, Nathanos saw the impossible: the Night Stalker was a woman with a face identical to his own. Her final words broke apart unfinished, and the living bandages from her back fell lifeless into the snow.

For a moment, the sight shook Nathanos to his core, but Raphael was bleeding out before him. Whatever horror the face had awakened, he forced it down and turned back to the living. Using his inner flame, he sealed Raphael's wound long enough to move. Raphael reminded him that the hunt was over, their fallen had not died for nothing, and Kalluth would need proof. Nathanos took the bone-white mask, fastened it to his belt, and carried Raphael away from the clearing, leaving the dead behind until they could return.

Snow continued to drift down from a pale, colorless sky.

High above the forest floor, beneath the shelter of black pine needles, a small bird bent over its nest and pushed the last torn piece of food into the open mouths of its young. The hatchlings stirred blindly beneath her, their fragile throats stretching as thin cries rose into the cold, begging for more even after the last of the food was gone.

The mother bird lifted her head.

Something moved far below, between the trees.

Two figures emerged slowly from the white, making their way through the forest with the exhausted determination of men who had survived something they should not have. One walked beneath the weight of the other, whose arm hung heavily over his shoulder while his boots dragged through the snow in uneven lines, leaving behind a dark trail that the falling snow struggled to conceal.

The hatchlings cried again, hungry and unaware of the suffering passing beneath them, while their mother remained motionless upon the branch, her black eyes fixed on the wounded figures below.

The forest around them was quiet, though there was little peace to be found in that stillness. Something about the empty spaces between the trees seemed to invite attention, as though the woods were listening for a sound that had not yet come.

Then the bird spread her wings, scattering a dusting of snow from the branch, and disappeared into the grey winter sky.

Below her, Raphael made a low sound as he took another step.

It was not a word, nor anything close to one, but a strained expression of pain that escaped through his clenched teeth as his weight sagged more heavily against Nathanos. His eyes had remained closed for most of the journey, his lashes dusted with melting snow and his face pale beneath the blood and cold, while each breath came unevenly, catching somewhere deep inside his chest before he managed to draw another.

Every few steps, a faint trace of red gathered at the corner of his mouth.

Raphael swallowed it down, but Nathanos noticed.

He had noticed every change in his friend since they left the clearing, from the weakening of his steps and the trembling in his knees to the increasingly shallow breaths that sometimes carried a wetness Nathanos could not bear to hear. He watched Raphael with the same vigilance he gave the forest around them, his blue eyes moving between the trees and the wounded man leaning against him, unwilling to allow either out of his attention for long.

The Night Stalker was dead, but Velldendar had not suddenly become safe.

The Nightmares remained somewhere among the trees, perhaps distant and no longer hunting them, perhaps gathered in some darker part of the forest where the weak winter light could not reach. Nathanos could not know whether the creatures had lost their purpose with the death of their master, and he had seen enough of them to understand that silence was no reason to trust the woods.

Death did not always leave a forest harmless.

He listened for movement beneath the snow, for breathing that did not belong to either of them, and for the faint scraping of something following where no footsteps should have been. Every unusual sound made him tighten his hold around Raphael, but even when the forest remained undisturbed, his attention kept returning to the blood at the soldier's mouth and the wound concealed beneath his armor.

The flame had slowed the bleeding, yet Nathanos could not forget the strange resistance he had felt while trying to close it.

He had known something was wrong the moment the wound refused to seal properly, and when Raphael's blood continued escaping despite his efforts, the fear had only grown. The blade had passed deep through his body, and whatever damage it had left behind was more than Nathanos could safely mend through broken armor and scorched cloth.

He could keep the bleeding under control for now, but the difficulty of holding the wound closed made every movement a risk he could not afford to ignore.

“Raphael,” Nathanos said, his voice low and strained by the effort of keeping them both moving.

“Are you still with me?”

Raphael's head shifted faintly against his shoulder.

For a moment, Nathanos received no answer, and his grip tightened before the soldier finally managed a small, painful nod.

“Still here,” Raphael rasped.

The words were little more than a breath, nearly swallowed by the falling snow, but they were enough to ease the pressure in Nathanos's chest for another moment.

“Good,” he answered. “Stay that way.”

They continued through the trees, Nathanos bearing most of Raphael's weight with one arm locked around his back and the other ready to catch him whenever his legs threatened to fail. His own body ached from the cold and the strain of the battle, but he could not allow himself to slow while Raphael's breathing remained so uneven and the forest around them offered no certainty that they were alone.

A branch cracked somewhere to their left.

Nathanos stopped at once.

Raphael stirred weakly against him, but Nathanos held him steady and turned his attention toward the sound, searching the white gloom between the trunks. Snow continued falling in soft sheets, gathering upon the dark branches and settling over the disturbed ground, yet nothing moved among the trees and no unfamiliar breathing reached him through the silence.

For several heartbeats, there was only the winter wind and the ragged sound of their own breaths.

Eventually, Nathanos forced himself to move again.

Raphael's mouth twitched faintly, though his eyes remained closed.

“Jumping at birds now?”

“Save your breath.”

“That was almost an answer.”

“It was a warning.”

Raphael managed the faintest suggestion of a laugh, but it broke into a strained inhale before the sound could fully leave him. His fingers clenched in Nathanos's coat, and his weight dipped so suddenly that Nathanos nearly stumbled as he struggled to keep them both upright.

“Raphael.”

“I know,” he breathed. “Still here.”

“You keep saying that like it is enough.”

“It is working so far.”

Nathanos wanted to snap at him, to tell him that humor would do nothing to stop the bleeding inside his body and that pride would not carry him all the way to Kalluth. If Raphael collapsed here, beneath the trees and far from anyone who might properly treat him, Nathanos did not know whether his flame would be enough to save him again.

But before he could give voice to that fear, the trees ahead began to open.

Through the pines, the carrier came into view.

Its dark wooden frame stood among the trees, iron fittings dull beneath the frost and the crest of Kalluth half-concealed by a thin layer of snow. The two horses remained where they had been left, shifting restlessly beneath their harnesses while pale clouds of breath rose from their nostrils. Nearby stood the mounts of the fallen soldiers, their saddles empty and their ears twitching toward the surrounding forest as though they too sensed that something terrible had taken place beyond the trees.

“We're there,” Nathanos said quickly, tightening his arm around Raphael. “Do you hear me? Just a few more steps.”

Raphael opened his eyes long enough to see the carrier waiting ahead, his red gaze glassy beneath heavy lids, and a faint smile touched his mouth.

“Never doubted you,” he breathed.

The next step almost broke that lie.

Pain flared through his abdomen with such force that his fingers dug into Nathanos's coat, and for a moment the wound, the movement and the heat Nathanos had forced through his body seemed to become one unbearable sensation. Raphael could no longer distinguish the pain of the blade from the fire that had kept him alive, nor could he find a position that did not seem to pull at something deep inside him.

He clenched his teeth and tried to think of anything other than the wound.

His thoughts settled upon fire.

Not the pain burning through his abdomen, nor the blood gathering at his lips, but the holy flame that had been carried in the heart of Kalluth since the city's founding.

The Searing Flame.

Raphael had grown up hearing stories of it, just as everyone in Kalluth had, and he knew the old account of how the Matriarch of the Rannaketh had bestowed that sacred fire upon the city to protect it from the darkest creatures dwelling within Velldenar.

For generations, it had stood as a symbol of protection, a warning to anything born from shadow that Kalluth would not kneel before it, yet despite the reverence surrounding the flame, no one had been known to truly wield its power.

Not until High Exarch Alexandre.

And Nathanos.

Alexandre, leader of the Searing Flame and the right hand of King Aren Thornwell, could summon that holy fire into his hands as though prayer itself had been given form. He could shape it into judgment and punishment, turning its warmth into something that made even the creatures of darkness remember fear.

Nathanos possessed that same power.

The crown prince of Kalluth, whom some still whispered of as the cursed prince when they believed no loyal ears were near, carried within him the very flame that had protected their city for generations.

Raphael had felt it through his own body now, though not as judgment or destruction. He had felt it as warmth pressed into torn flesh, as fire restrained and forced into gentleness, holding him together when he should have been bleeding out into the snow.

He opened his eyes a little farther and looked at Nathanos.

The prince's face was fixed upon the carrier, his expression pale and severe while snow clung to his blond hair and lashes, gathering along the dark lines of his coat. His blue eyes remained focused ahead, as though the strength of his will alone might carry them there faster.

He looked nothing like the royal figure Raphael had followed into battle.

He looked exhausted, frightened, and far too aware of how little stood between his friend and death.

Yet he was still there, carrying Raphael through the snow with a determination that had not faltered since the clearing.

Raphael's thoughts drifted toward the older stories, fever and exhaustion making the memories seem distant and strangely close at once. He remembered the Day of Madness, Eneth Thornwell and the companions who had drawn the Lord of Dread from the shadows with that same sacred flame, standing against him when the world had begun to break.

Eneth had been Raphael's idol for as long as he could remember, a hero whose legacy had shaped much of what he believed it meant to serve Kalluth.

Now another Thornwell carried the same fire.

There was something almost impossible about it, Raphael thought dimly, some pattern connecting the old horrors to the darkness they had faced in the forest. Perhaps it was only the pain making him search for meaning, but he could not help thinking of searing flame answering dread, of the Thornwell bloodline standing against the things other men feared to face.

Nathanos had walked into that same darkness.

But he had not gone alone.

Raphael remembered the Nightstalker struggling against him, the bandages writhing over his armor and the clawed hands searching desperately for somewhere to strike. He had held her with everything he had left, knowing that without his grip she would escape and that Nathanos would lose the only opening they had been given.

He had known the blade would have to pass through him as well.

Still, he had held her.

Together, they had brought down the terror of the southern region, a creature tied again and again to the Lord of Dread, ending the hunt through Thornwell flame and Marchand blood.

The thought almost became something greater in Raphael's pain-clouded mind, something he wanted to follow, but before he could grasp it, Nathanos shifted beneath him and tightened his hold.

“We're here,” Nathanos said.

The carrier stood before them now, close enough that Nathanos could reach for its door.

Raphael released a trembling breath, relief softening his expression for the briefest moment before the pain returned.

“Good,” he whispered. “I was starting to think you were taking the scenic route.”

Nathanos looked at him sharply, worry and exhaustion written plainly across his face, but Raphael's faint smile remained for another moment before his eyes closed again.

Nathanos did not waste another word. He guided Raphael toward the carrier, listening to the surrounding trees even as he reached for the door, unwilling to trust that the forest would allow them to leave without sending one final horror after them.

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The carrier door opened with a heavy groan of wood and iron, allowing the cold wind to rush into the small space within. Snow followed, scattering in pale flecks across the floorboards and benches as Nathanos helped Raphael through the entrance, struggling to guide him over the step without allowing his weight to fall against the wound.

Raphael could offer little assistance. His arm hung heavily over Nathanos's shoulder, his boots dragged across the wooden threshold, and every breath left him rough and uneven, as though his body had forgotten how to draw air without first fighting for it.

“Easy,” Nathanos murmured, holding him close as they made their way inside.

There was little of the commander in his voice now, only the quiet concern of someone trying desperately not to let his fear become panic.

He pulled the door mostly shut behind them, leaving a narrow opening through which the last of the winter light entered, and steadied Raphael before his failing legs could carry him down.

For a moment, Nathanos looked around the carrier.

Dark, polished wood covered the interior, with iron fittings securing two cushioned benches facing one another along either side. Each was wide enough to accommodate two passengers in relative comfort, provided the roads were kind and those traveling had not just escaped a slaughter. Pillows rested at their ends, stitched in deep royal colors that appeared subdued beneath the grey light, while frost gathered at the corners of the small windows and along the glass set into the door.

Four candle holders were fixed into the ceiling frame, their blackened wicks waiting for nightfall. Above the benches and within the compartments beneath them lay the supplies intended for longer journeys: wrapped food, water flasks, folded cloths, spare utensils, a small knife and other ordinary necessities that seemed strangely out of place after everything they had left behind.

It was a royal carrier, built for distance and comfort, perhaps even for the dignity expected of those who traveled beneath the crest of the Thornwells.

It had never been intended for this.

Nathanos guided Raphael toward the nearest bench, supporting most of his weight as the soldier's knees threatened to fail. He lowered him carefully into the far corner, turning him just enough for his shoulder plate to rest against the wooden side and the cushioned back without placing unnecessary pressure upon his abdomen.

Raphael sank into the seat with a strained breath, his head tipping backward as his eyes drifted half-closed.

For several moments, Nathanos remained before him, watching the uneven rise and fall of his chest. Every breath seemed to demand more effort than the last, his body trembling faintly as it fought the wound, while pain continued to pass across his face despite the exhaustion threatening to draw him into unconsciousness.

The bleeding had slowed, but Nathanos could not trust that it would remain so.

Not after the difficulty he had already experienced trying to seal it.

Raphael's lips parted slightly, dry and pale beneath the blood that had gathered at the corner of his mouth, and Nathanos looked toward the candle holders above them.

The carrier was too dim for what he needed to do, and the cold that had settled inside would offer Raphael little comfort.

He raised his hand toward the first candle, setting two fingers carefully around its wax stem before allowing a small golden flame to gather at their tips. The wick caught almost immediately, its light trembling against the dark wood as Nathanos moved to the next.

He lit the remaining candles in turn, guiding his inner flame with such care that the warmth never came close to harming the wooden frame. One by one, the small lights stirred to life, spreading a softer glow through the carrier until the polished interior, Raphael's pale face and the blood-darkened armor were illuminated by their unsteady gold.

Only then did Nathanos turn toward the storage compartment.

He opened it and searched among the supplies until he found a folded cloth, a glass, a knife and a water flask. The glass knocked softly against the wood as he brought it down, his hands trembling more than he wished them to, and he set the supplies beside Raphael before crouching in front of him.

A thin line of blood still marked the corner of Raphael's mouth, left there during the slow and painful journey through the forest. It had begun to dry against his skin, darkening the pale face that Nathanos had been watching with increasing concern.

He folded the cloth around his fingers and carefully wiped it away.

Raphael's eyes opened slightly, unfocused at first, before settling upon him.

“It's only blood,” he whispered, as though the words might make it less troubling.

“I know,” Nathanos answered softly.

He continued wiping until the last of the dark smear was gone.

Only then did he reach for the flask and pour water into the glass, the clear surface catching the candlelight as it trembled in his unsteady hand.

“Drink,” he said, bringing it closer.

Raphael opened his eyes a little farther, and something of his familiar defiance tried to return.

“I can...”

“No.” Nathanos stopped him before he could attempt to move, though his voice softened almost immediately. He steadied Raphael with one hand, unwilling to let him lean forward and pull at the wound. “Don't. Please. The wound has opened once already. If it tears again...”

He could not finish the thought.

Raphael watched him through the pain, understanding what Nathanos had left unsaid, while the prince swallowed and lifted the glass a little closer.

“Let me do this,” he murmured. “Just this once.”

For a moment, the familiar smile tried to return to Raphael's mouth.

“You make it sound like I have a choice.”

Nathanos's expression softened despite himself.

“You don't.”

Raphael gave the smallest nod, allowing Nathanos to support the back of his head and bring the glass to his lips. He tilted it carefully, offering only a little water at first so that Raphael would not have to struggle with more than he could comfortably swallow.

Even that small amount seemed to demand an effort.

Raphael swallowed slowly, his throat working with visible discomfort, and some of the water escaped at the corner of his mouth before slipping toward his jaw. Nathanos caught it with his thumb before it could reach the collar of his armor, then adjusted the glass to offer him another small sip.

“Slowly,” he murmured. “Not too much.”

This time Raphael obeyed without protest. He drank in small, painful swallows, closing his eyes whenever he needed to steady his breathing, while Nathanos kept the glass near his lips and watched every movement with an attention that made even this ordinary act feel delicate.

When Raphael finally turned his face away, Nathanos lowered the glass.

“Enough?”

Raphael swallowed once more before giving a faint nod.

“For now,” he whispered, his eyes barely open. “Thank you, Nathanos.”

Nathanos set the glass aside, close enough to reach again if Raphael needed it, and turned his attention toward the wound.

The soldier's head remained against the wooden side of the carrier, his breathing still too fast and shallow despite the small amount of water he had managed to drink. Candlelight moved across his armor and caught upon the blood that had dried between its plates, illuminating the scorched edges where Nathanos's blade had passed through him.

Nathanos stared at the damaged metal.

The wound remained hidden beneath steel, leather and cloth, concealed further by the desperate work his flame had done in the snow. All he could see from outside was the torn fabric, the darkened edges and the place where the heat had sealed what should otherwise have been an injury no man could survive.

It was not enough.

He needed to know what lay beneath the armor, and whether the wound he had struggled so desperately to close was still holding.

Raphael noticed his silence and opened his eyes.

“That look usually means pain.”

Nathanos did not attempt to deny it.

“I need to remove the armor.”

Raphael's mouth tightened, and for a moment he looked down toward his chest before returning his attention to the prince.

Nathanos leaned closer, keeping his voice low.

“I have to see the wound properly, Raphael. I can't tell what is happening beneath the steel, and I don't know how much damage the blade has done.” He glanced toward the supplies he had gathered. “There's water here, clean cloth, blankets and spare clothes. I'll clean what I can, make certain the wound is still sealed and get you out of this armor before its weight makes anything worse.”

Raphael studied him through fever-bright eyes, struggling to maintain his focus.

“And during this?” he asked.

“You do not move unless I tell you to.” Nathanos paused, allowing the command in his voice to soften. “Not because I think you're weak. But if that wound tears again, Raphael...”

He stopped before the thought could become words.

Raphael understood him anyway.

A faint breath escaped him, almost resembling a laugh, though it carried little humor.

“I always imagined being undressed by someone with a little less royal authority.”

Despite himself, Nathanos almost smiled.

Almost.

“This is not the time.”

“No,” Raphael whispered. “I know.”

Yet something of the awkwardness remained between them, visible even through the pain and exhaustion on Raphael's face. It was not merely the prospect of Nathanos removing his armor and tending to him in such a vulnerable state. Nathanos was a man, a prince, and more than that, a Thornwell, descended from the same bloodline as the hero Raphael had admired for as long as he could remember.

There was something deeply uncomfortable about surrendering so much of himself before someone he respected, about allowing the man he had followed into battle to see him helpless and unable to perform even the simplest task without assistance.

This was no longer a matter of rank, nor of the pride he usually carried as a commander.

It was something far more intimate.

Raphael lowered his gaze for a moment before offering a small nod.

“Do it.”

Nathanos moved carefully, beginning with the shoulder plates.

His fingers found the first fastening near Raphael's collar, working the strap loose with slow precision. The leather had stiffened beneath the cold and dried blood, resisting his attempts to free it, but Nathanos refused to pull harder and risk dragging the plate against Raphael's injured body. He adjusted his grip, eased the buckle free and supported the heavy metal before allowing it to move.

“Gentle,” Raphael breathed.

“I know,” Nathanos answered softly. “I have you.”

The first shoulder plate came away with a dull shift of metal.

Raphael inhaled sharply, though this time the movement was accompanied by relief rather than pain. His shoulders settled a little farther into the bench, as though some of the weight pressing upon him had finally been lifted.

Nathanos placed the plate upon the floorboards and moved to the second fastening, working it free with the same care.

Without the heavy iron upon his shoulders, Raphael seemed smaller, the imposing figure of the commander slowly giving way to the exhausted man beneath the armor. Nathanos had seen him wounded before, but never like this, never so helpless that even removing his own equipment had become something he could no longer manage.

He reached for the red cloak next.

The fabric had grown damp and heavy with snowmelt and blood, clinging to Raphael's shoulders as Nathanos carefully loosened it and drew it away. The golden medallion fastened near the front on his right side caught the candlelight as it moved, the sigil of the Searing Flame still visible beneath the dark smears marking its surface.

For a moment, Nathanos's hand paused upon it.

Then he placed the cloak beside the discarded shoulder plates, leaving the medallion resting against the red fabric.

Raphael watched him through half-lidded eyes.

There was no jest waiting upon his lips this time, only the quiet discomfort of needing such help and the trust that allowed him to accept it.

Then Nathanos turned toward the chestplate.

Four main fastenings held it in place, two belts crossing high near the shoulders and another two secured beneath the arms. All of them were dark with blood and damp from the snow that had melted against the armor, and Nathanos examined their positions before reaching for the first.

He loosened the upper belt carefully, drawing the stiff leather through its buckle without allowing the metal beneath it to shift.

Raphael made a low sound through his teeth.

Nathanos looked at him at once.

“Keep going,” Raphael murmured, shaking his head faintly.

Nathanos hesitated only long enough to make certain he was ready before returning to the fastening.

The second shoulder belt came free after a moment, followed by the first at the side and then the other. Each buckle loosened with a soft scrape of leather and metal, but Raphael's breathing became thinner with every movement, his fingers curling against the bench before relaxing again as he struggled to remain still.

Nathanos watched him closely throughout, unwilling to mistake silence for an absence of pain, while Raphael kept his eyes half-closed and concentrated upon each breath.

At last, all four fastenings were undone.

The chestplate was free enough to lift.

Nathanos placed one hand beneath its lower edge and the other against Raphael's side, supporting him so that the movement would not draw his body forward. He looked down at the darkened metal, the scorched cloth visible beneath it and the blood that had dried around the place where his blade had struck.

He did not trust any of it.

“Slowly,” Raphael whispered.

“Yes.”

Nathanos began to lift the plate.

He moved it only a little before something resisted.

At first, he thought one of the fastenings had caught, or that the leather beneath the armor had become tangled, but the sensation against his fingers was unlike the resistance of a buckle or strap.

Something was pulling from beneath the plate.

He tried to adjust the angle without raising it any farther, and the tension followed, stretching with the movement as though something living had taken hold of the metal from within.

Before he could understand what was happening, Raphael screamed.

The sound tore through the carrier with such force that Nathanos froze, the chestplate still caught in his hands while Raphael's head struck back against the wooden side. His body arched despite every effort to remain still, his fingers clawing desperately at the bench as his nails scraped through the fabric, and tears spilled from his eyes before he could draw enough breath to cry out again.

Outside, a flock of small birds erupted from the nearby trees, their wings scattering snow from the branches as they fled into the grey air.

Nathanos did not move.

He held the armor exactly where it was, terrified that lifting it farther might cause even greater harm, while fresh blood began to well from beneath its lower edge and run over his fingers.

Raphael's scream broke into a choking gasp.

“Stop,” he begged. “Stop...”

“I stopped.” Nathanos's voice came out strained, but he kept his hands steady. “I'm not moving it.”

“It feels...” Raphael struggled to draw another breath, his face wet with tears as pain continued to tremble through him. “It feels like you're ripping my skin off.”

The words struck Nathanos harder than the scream.

He looked down at the narrow space beneath the armor, where blood, scorched cloth and sealed flesh disappeared into one another, and for a moment his mind refused to understand what his hands had felt.

The candlelight flickered across the darkened steel.

Then he remembered.

His flame.

The heat he had forced into the wound in the clearing, the desperate sealing of the flesh and the scorched edges of the cloth and leather pressed beneath Raphael's armor. The metal had been tight against his body when Nathanos had tried to stop the bleeding, and he had concentrated upon closing the injury without being able to see what the fire was doing beneath the plate.

His stomach turned as the pieces came together.

He had not merely sealed Raphael's flesh.

He might have burned it into the armor itself.

“No,” Nathanos whispered.

He looked from the wounded soldier to the chestplate still held in his hands, his face growing pale beneath the candlelight as the horror of what he might have done settled upon him.

“No, this can't be...”

Raphael watched him through clenched teeth, struggling to breathe as fresh fear entered his expression. He had felt the pull, felt the terrible resistance beneath his skin, and now he understood what Nathanos had only just begun to realize.

“It happened when you sealed it,” Raphael said, his voice thin and unsteady.

Nathanos could not answer.

The flame had saved Raphael's life in the clearing, forcing torn flesh to close when there had been no other way to stop the bleeding, but in doing so it had left the armor bound to the very wound it had been meant to protect.

He had kept his friend alive.

And now Raphael was trapped beneath the result of his healing.

Raphael swallowed, fighting to remain conscious through the pain.

“You couldn't have known.”

“I should have.”

“No.” His fingers trembled against the ruined fabric of the bench. “You have never done it like this before. Not through armor. Not through cloth. Not with me bleeding out in the snow.”

Nathanos lowered the plate just enough to ease the tension, taking care not to press it back into the injured flesh. His hand remained beneath its edge, bloodied fingers supporting the metal because he no longer trusted what would happen if he allowed it to settle against Raphael's body.

For several moments, neither man spoke.

The birds outside had disappeared, leaving only the wind moving through the trees, while Raphael's breathing shook in the silence of the carrier.

“If it stays like this,” he whispered at last, “it will kill me.”

Nathanos lifted his gaze.

Raphael's face remained wet with tears, his skin pale beneath the feverish flush left by the pain, but his red eyes stayed fixed upon Nathanos.

“The wound will rot beneath it,” he continued. “The road will pull at it. Every movement. Every turn. If the metal has sealed into me...”

His voice faltered as another wave of pain passed through him.

“Then we already know the answer.”

Nathanos's jaw tightened.

He could not leave the armor where it was, not when every movement of the carrier might pull at the wound and undo the fragile seal he had struggled to maintain. Yet the pain Raphael had endured from that one small movement made the thought of removing it almost unbearable.

For several heartbeats, Nathanos considered what remained available to him, searching desperately for something that might allow him to free the plate without tearing the wound open again.

Then he looked at the metal beneath his hand.

“I may have another way.”

Raphael closed his eyes for a moment.

“I hate that sentence.”

“I can heat the armor.”

Raphael opened his eyes again, looking at Nathanos as though he needed to be certain he had heard him correctly.

Nathanos continued before either of them could allow the thought to become worse than it already was.

“The flame itself won't burn you. I can control that much. But the metal will take the heat, and if I can soften what has sealed against it, I might be able to loosen the plate enough to remove it without tearing everything open.”

Raphael stared at him.

“And if it doesn't loosen?”

Nathanos could not bring himself to offer him a promise he did not know he could keep.

“Then part of the skin may still come with it.”

Raphael's lips parted, but no words came.

For a moment, he looked away, not because he doubted Nathanos or blamed him for what had happened, but because the thought of what might follow was too much to bear while looking at the man who would have to do it.

“Raphael...” Nathanos began quietly.

“I know.”

“You don't have to answer at once.”

“Yes,” Raphael whispered. “I do.”

Nathanos shook his head faintly, but Raphael looked back at him, and there was nothing left to conceal the fear in his expression.

“If this stays, I die slower. If you try, I might survive.” His breath caught before he could continue. “I do not like those choices.”

“Neither do I.”

“But there they are.”

The carrier creaked softly around them, its wooden frame shifting beneath the winter wind while Nathanos remained crouched before Raphael, one bloodied hand still supporting the armor.

Raphael swallowed hard, then gave the smallest nod.

“Do it.”

Nathanos's eyes tightened, the fear he had been struggling to contain passing briefly across his face.

Raphael saw it and tried to steady him, even now, when he was the one facing the pain.

“You are not doing this to me, Nathanos. You are doing it for me.”

The words nearly broke something in him.

Nathanos lowered his gaze, drawing a careful breath through his nose as he forced the fear back into his hands, where it could become something useful. He could not allow himself to tremble while holding the plate, nor could he afford to hesitate once the metal began to loosen.

He needed Raphael to survive what came next.

With his clean hand, Nathanos reached beneath the bench and pulled out one of the folded towels stored there for travel. He shook it open, folded it twice and then once more, making it thick enough to withstand the pressure of Raphael's teeth without becoming too large for him to hold comfortably in his mouth.

Raphael watched him.

His eyes changed as he understood what Nathanos was preparing, and the fear he had tried so hard to master returned.

“No,” he breathed.

“I need you to bite down on this.”

Raphael glanced toward the carrier door, toward the darkening forest beyond it.

“Because of the scream.”

“And because of your teeth.” Nathanos brought the folded towel closer but did not force it upon him. “If the pain comes hard, you need something between them.”

Raphael's breathing became shallow.

For the first time since Nathanos had brought him into the carrier, the soldier looked terribly young beneath the blood, command and noble pride he usually carried. The fear in his eyes was not the fear of battle, nor the prospect of some heroic death that might one day be remembered in song, but something painfully immediate.

He was afraid of what Nathanos was about to do.

Afraid of the metal against his skin, of the next movement and of the moment the heat would begin to pass through the armor.

Nathanos leaned closer.

“I’ll be as careful as I can.”

“I know.”

“I’ll stop if I have to.”

Raphael gave a faint, bitter shake of his head.

“No. If you stop every time I want you to, we’ll never finish.”

Nathanos fell silent.

Raphael looked at him, his eyes shining with tears beneath the candlelight.

“Just... stay with me.”

Nathanos's expression softened.

“I am not leaving you.”

The words settled between them, quiet and certain, and Raphael held his gaze for another moment before opening his mouth.

Nathanos placed the folded towel carefully between his teeth, adjusting it so that he could bite down without obstructing his breathing. Raphael closed his jaw around it, the movement already trembling with anticipation, while Nathanos returned his bloodied hand beneath the chestplate and positioned his other hand over the metal.

A faint golden light began to gather beneath his fingers, no brighter than the flames burning in the candles above them.

Raphael kept his eyes upon him.

Nathanos looked back.

Neither of them could conceal the fear now, but Raphael did not turn away, and Nathanos refused to let his own uncertainty prevent him from doing what had to be done.

He allowed the flame to deepen.

Nathanos fed the flame into the metal slowly, guiding its warmth through the chestplate in carefully controlled breaths rather than allowing the fire to spread all at once. Golden light gathered beneath his fingers and moved across the darkened surface, faint at first, until the armor began to absorb the heat.

Raphael stiffened as the first warmth reached him.

His jaw tightened around the folded towel, and he pressed his shoulders more firmly against the bench, trying to remain as still as Nathanos had instructed while the metal grew warmer beneath the prince's hand.

Nathanos watched his expression closely, searching for the slightest indication that the heat had become too much, but he could not allow himself to stop before the armor had begun to loosen.

He guided more of his flame into the plate.

The metal answered.

Raphael's eyes widened as the warmth reached the places where the armor had fused to his body. Unlike the flame Nathanos commanded, the heated metal offered no gentleness to the wounded flesh beneath it, and the pain began to climb through his abdomen until every muscle in his body tightened against the bench.

A muffled sound escaped into the towel, low at first, before rising into something sharper as Raphael's teeth sank deeper into the folded cloth.

Nathanos kept his attention fixed upon him.

“I know,” he whispered, his voice strained by the effort of maintaining control. “I know. Hold on.”

The armor grew hotter.

A thin hiss rose from beneath the chestplate, almost too quiet to hear over Raphael's breathing, but Nathanos recognized it immediately. Blood and scorched cloth had begun to react to the heat, and the flesh that had sealed against the metal was being forced apart from what it had become fused to.

The sound was small, almost delicate, and somehow made what he was doing feel even more terrible.

A wet, burning whisper filled the carrier, followed by the sharp scent of scorched blood and heated iron. Beneath it came another smell, heavier and more difficult to bear, as the damaged flesh began to loosen from the armor.

It spread through the candlelit air until even the cold wind slipping through the door could no longer conceal it.

Raphael shook beneath him.

His hands clawed at the bench again, nails dragging through the fabric while his shoulders pressed desperately against the wooden back. Tears ran freely down his temples and along his jaw, mingling with the sweat gathering around his throat, and every breath came broken through his nose as his body struggled against the pain.

The towel smothered the worst of his cries, but Nathanos could still hear them.

He heard each muffled scream, each strained breath and each desperate sound Raphael made when another wave of pain passed through him. He could see the way his friend tried to keep his body still, could feel the tremors passing through him, and the knowledge that his own flame was responsible threatened to break the concentration he needed to maintain.

Yet the resistance beneath the plate was beginning to change.

Nathanos felt it through his fingers, a subtle loosening where the armor had previously seemed rooted into Raphael's body. The pull had not disappeared, but something in the fused flesh and cloth had begun to give way beneath the heat, softening enough that he could feel the metal shift without immediately dragging the entire wound with it.

He tested the movement carefully, raising the plate only enough to understand what had changed.

There was still resistance.

But it was weaker.

Nathanos looked at Raphael.

His friend's red eyes found his, wet and wild with pain, and for one terrible moment they remained fixed upon one another while the heated metal continued to burn against the damaged flesh.

Raphael knew what came next.

He had felt the armor begin to loosen, and whatever relief that should have brought was swallowed by the knowledge that Nathanos would have to pull it free before the wound could close around it again.

Nathanos tightened his grip.

“Forgive me.”

Then he tore the chestplate free in one hard motion.

Raphael's scream crushed itself into the towel as his entire body arched away from the bench.

The armor came loose with a wet, ripping sound, scorched fabric tearing with it as pieces of blood-darkened flesh remained clinging to the inner side of the plate.

Fresh blood surged from the exposed wound, spilling hot over Nathanos's hand, and for one dreadful heartbeat he feared that the movement had torn open everything he had struggled to seal in the clearing.

But the wound held.

The damage was terrible, and the sudden bleeding made it difficult to see how much flesh had been pulled away, yet the deeper seal remained intact enough to prevent the injury from opening completely.

The flame had saved Raphael once more, though Nathanos could scarcely bear to look at what it had cost him.

The chestplate burned against his palm.

Even with his control over the holy flame, the metal itself had grown too hot to hold, and Nathanos threw it aside before the heat could do more damage to his hand.

It struck the floorboards with a heavy clang, smoking faintly where torn cloth and dark remnants of flesh still clung to its inner surface.

Raphael sagged back against the bench.

His body trembled so violently that the cushions shifted beneath him, and though his eyes remained open, they seemed unable to settle upon anything before him. His face had gone almost entirely white, broken only by the feverish flush spreading across his cheeks, while sweat covered his brow, throat and exposed skin.

The folded towel remained clenched between his teeth, damp with his breath, and the sounds escaping around it were no longer recognizable as words.

Nathanos wanted to reach for him.

He wanted to tell him that the worst was over, that he could rest now and that he had endured enough, but the fresh blood gathering beneath the wound would not allow him to offer either of them that comfort.

Not yet.

He bent over Raphael at once, bringing his attention to the exposed injury.

The armor had not come away cleanly.

Small fragments remained embedded near the sealed flesh, dark points of metal and burned cloth caught along the damaged edges where the chestplate had resisted being removed. Some were barely large enough to distinguish beneath the blood, yet Nathanos could not leave them there, not when the wound had already proven so difficult to close and every foreign piece threatened to complicate what little healing he had managed.

He brought his flame back, smaller this time, reducing it to a narrow thread of gold between his fingers.

Carefully, he touched the heat to the remaining fragments, burning away the cloth and loosening the metal without allowing the fire to spread farther into Raphael's body. Every movement demanded precision, and Nathanos forced himself to work slowly even as his friend's exhausted body continued trembling beneath him.

Raphael jerked with every touch.

The sounds he made were no longer full screams, but broken, muffled sobs that shook through his chest and died against the towel. His hands had stopped clawing at the bench, his fingers now curled weakly against the ruined fabric, as though even the effort of gripping something had become too much for him.

“I'm almost done,” Nathanos said, his voice rough with the strain of keeping his flame steady.

“Raphael, stay with me. Almost done.”

He loosened a small piece of metal and carefully pushed it free with the side of his finger, watching the wound as he removed it to make certain the surrounding flesh remained closed.

Another fragment followed.

Then a blackened thread of cloth came loose, clinging wetly to his skin before he cast it aside.

He continued working with terrible care, each movement small and deliberate, his breath catching whenever Raphael's body jerked beneath his hand. The smallest mistake might undo everything he had done, and Nathanos refused to allow his fear to hurry him while there was still something trapped inside the wound.

At last, the final fragment came free.

The armor was gone, the burned cloth had been removed, and nothing remained embedded along the edges of the flesh that his flame had accidentally fused to the plate.

Only then did Nathanos reach for the knife.

He cut through what remained of Raphael's ruined gambeson and undershirt, slicing the fabric from the torn edge upward before carefully pulling it away from his chest and shoulders. The material had stiffened with dried blood and scorched patches, coming free in heavy pieces that Nathanos placed beside the other discarded clothing.

Beneath it, Raphael looked painfully human.

The armor that usually gave him such an imposing presence was gone, leaving only bare skin, sweat, spreading bruises and the blood that had run across his abdomen. Without the familiar weight of steel and the red cloak upon his shoulders, there was little left of the commander Nathanos had fought beside for so many years.

There was only his friend, exhausted and trembling, with a terrible wound where the blade had passed through him.

Nathanos stared at it.

The flesh had closed, but it had not healed properly.

The edges remained scorched and uneven, angry beneath the candlelight, marked by the passage of the sword and the desperate heat Nathanos had forced through them. Even now, he could feel that strange resistance when he allowed the smallest amount of flame to pass over the injury, the flesh refusing to yield fully despite his efforts.

Whatever lay beneath the wound remained beyond what he could safely mend here.

And the damage left upon the surface would never truly disappear.

Even if Raphael survived, even if he returned to Kalluth and recovered enough to walk, fight and laugh as he had before, the marks of what had happened in the clearing would remain upon his body.

A scar for life.

But the chestplate was gone, and with it the scorched cloth and fragments of metal that had become trapped against the wound. Nathanos no longer had to fear that the armor would tear at Raphael with every movement or that the filth sealed beneath it would remain pressed against the damaged flesh throughout their journey.

He could finally see what he was treating.

Nathanos forced himself to move.

He reached for the clean water and a fresh cloth, wetting it carefully before beginning to wash the blood from Raphael's abdomen.

Raphael flinched at the first touch, a weak tremor passing through him as the damp fabric moved across the injured skin, but he no longer possessed the strength to resist. His eyes drifted half-closed, wet lashes trembling against his cheeks while his breathing remained thin and uneven.

Yet he continued breathing.

Nathanos held on to that small certainty as he worked, because after everything Raphael had endured, it was the only reassurance he could allow himself to trust.

He cleaned the wound as gently as possible, removing the worst of the blood before wiping the dark streaks that had run across Raphael's chest, side and stomach. He worked around the damaged flesh rather than pulling at it, pausing whenever Raphael's breathing changed, until at last the injury was clean enough that he could properly see what remained.

Then Nathanos reached up and eased the towel from Raphael's mouth.

His jaw slackened as the folded cloth came free, but no words followed, only a broken breath that seemed to demand what little strength he had left.

Nathanos brushed a damp strand of hair away from his face, his touch gentle even now, as though anything less might cause Raphael to break beneath his hands.

“It's done,” he said softly. “The armor is off. The wound is clean.”

Raphael's eyes moved faintly toward him.

He tried to answer, but his lips parted without forming a word, and Nathanos shook his head before he could force himself to speak.

“I know. Don't speak.”

He lifted the glass again and brought it carefully toward Raphael's mouth, supporting the back of his head with one hand while offering him a small amount of water.

This time, Raphael made no attempt to help.

He swallowed with visible difficulty, his breathing trembling between each sip, and Nathanos waited patiently before allowing any more water to pass his lips.

“Slowly,” he murmured. “You're safe now. I've got you. Everything will be alright.”

Raphael managed another swallow.

Then one more.

When he could take no more, Nathanos lowered the glass and placed it aside, keeping his attention upon Raphael until he was certain his breathing had settled enough for him to continue.

From the storage beneath the bench, he retrieved the spare clothes prepared for travel, finding a clean shirt soft enough to rest against Raphael's injured body without the weight and roughness of armor.

He dressed him carefully, guiding the fabric over one arm and then the other while lifting him only as much as necessary, each movement performed with the same attention he had given the wound.

Raphael remained limp through most of it, too exhausted to protest or offer the familiar jest that Nathanos might otherwise have expected. Whatever remained of his pride had been overwhelmed by the pain, leaving him dependent upon the prince's hands even for the gentlest movement.

When the shirt was in place, Nathanos reached for a folded blanket and wrapped it around Raphael's shoulders, drawing it close enough to offer warmth while keeping the fabric loose around the injury.

Only then did he sit back.

The ruined chestplate lay upon the floorboards, still giving off the faintest trace of smoke, while the smell of burned cloth and blood lingered beneath the warmer scent of candle wax.

Raphael breathed.

Nathanos watched him, his hands trembling now that he no longer had to force them into the precision the treatment had demanded.

For several moments, he could do nothing else.

Then the smell reached him again.

Burned cloth.

Blood.

Skin.

His gaze drifted toward the ruined chestplate despite himself, settling upon the torn fabric clinging to its inner surface and the dark remnants he could not bring himself to name.

He remembered the resistance beneath his fingers, the terrible sound the armor had made when it finally came free and the way Raphael had screamed into the towel as his body arched against the bench.

His throat tightened.

Nathanos reached for another water flask, his hand shaking as he pulled the stopper free and brought it to his mouth. He drank deeply, swallowing again and again until the flask was empty and the cold water hurt going down, but even then he could still smell the burned flesh.

He could still see it.

When the flask was empty, it slipped from his fingers and struck the floorboards with a dull sound.

He did not pick it up.

Too much death had already come from the Nightstalker that day, too many men left behind in the snow and too many faces he would have to remember when the silence finally found him. The horror of what he had witnessed beneath the mask remained somewhere inside him, waiting beyond the urgency that had kept him moving since the clearing.

He could not allow himself to face it now.

Not while Raphael still needed him.

The Nightstalker would not claim his friend as well.

Nathanos leaned forward and reached beneath the blanket, finding Raphael's hand where it rested limply against his side. His fingers closed around it carefully at first, then tightened as though the warmth of his grip might keep Raphael from slipping any farther away.

“Raphael,” he said quietly.

There was no answer.

Only the thin, uneven sound of his breathing.

Nathanos moved closer.

“I'm going outside now. I'll drive the carrier from the front, but I will stop whenever I can and check on you. Again and again, if I have to.”

Raphael's lashes trembled faintly.

“If you need me, you call for me. Scream if you must. I will hear you.”

Still, Raphael did not answer.

Nathanos tightened his hold upon his hand, feeling the weakness in the fingers that had once gripped a sword with such certainty.

“You are strong,” he whispered. “Stronger than anyone I know. So do not die on me. Not now. Not after this.”

His thumb moved gently across Raphael's knuckles beneath the blanket.

“Promise me.”

Raphael remained silent.

His chest rose and fell beneath the clean shirt, each breath shallow and broken, but no words came to offer Nathanos the reassurance he was waiting for.

He held on for another heartbeat, unwilling to release the hand resting in his own.

Then he forced himself to let go.

Before opening the carrier door, Nathanos looked once more toward the ruined chestplate.

He could not leave it there.

Raphael would not be forced to breathe that stench for the entire journey to Kalluth, nor would Nathanos allow him to wake, even half-conscious, and find the bloodied armor lying beside him as a reminder of what had been torn from his body.

He had suffered enough.

Nathanos bent down and caught the plate by one of its cooler edges, lifting it from the floorboards with a grimace as the remaining heat reached his fingers.

Then he opened the carrier door.

Cold wind rushed inside, striking his face and carrying the smell of winter through the blood-heavy air.

Nathanos stepped down into the snow and threw the chestplate as far as he could.

It disappeared into the white with a dull, smoking thud.

For several moments, he remained outside, drawing deep breaths of the clean winter air and allowing the cold to cut through the terrible smell still lingering inside his lungs.

Then he looked back toward the carrier.

Raphael was inside.

Alive.

For now.

Nathanos closed the door carefully, leaving the four candles burning within, and turned toward the horses.

The two carrier horses remained where they had been left, secured beneath their harnesses to a nearby tree. Their hooves shifted restlessly against the snow, and pale clouds of breath rose from their nostrils into the darkening air.

Beyond them, other horses stood between the trees.

The mounts of the fallen.

They remained where their riders had left them, reins secured to low branches and saddles slowly gathering snow. Some shifted anxiously, stamping against the frozen ground, while others stood so still that they seemed almost part of the winter landscape.

Nathanos's chest tightened.

He could not take them all with him, and he could not return to bury the men who had ridden them, not while Raphael's life still depended upon reaching Kalluth as quickly as possible.

But he could not leave the animals tied here either.

Whatever continued moving through the Dark Forest after nightfall, he would not abandon them to it without giving them at least the chance to escape.

Nathanos approached the nearest horse and raised two fingers toward the rope holding it.

A thin line of golden flame slipped from his hand, touching the cord until it burned through with a quiet snap.

The horse startled backward, its head rising sharply as the severed rope fell into the snow.

“Go,” Nathanos said.

The animal hesitated, looking toward the trees before taking a few uncertain steps away from the place where it had been bound.

Nathanos moved to the next horse.

Then the next.

One by one, he burned through the ropes holding them, guiding his flame with enough precision that each brief flicker of gold disappeared the moment the cord gave way.

The horses began to move through the snow, slowly at first, their hesitation giving way as they followed one another farther from the carrier. Hooves struck the frozen ground, tails vanished between the trunks and pale clouds of breath moved through the white until the last of them broke into a gallop and disappeared into the darkening forest.

Nathanos watched them go.

He did not know whether they would survive the cold or whatever creatures still wandered beneath the trees, but at least they would not remain bound there, waiting for a rider who would never return.

When the last blackened rope had fallen into the snow, Nathanos stood alone among the pines.

The wind moved through the branches overhead, carrying the quiet rustle of falling snow, while somewhere behind him lay the hut and the bodies of the men who had followed him into battle.

The bone-white mask at his belt seemed heavier than before.

Nathanos turned back toward the carrier.

The two horses remained where he had left them, their harnesses secured and their breath rising in thick clouds against the cold. He approached the nearest one, resting a hand briefly against its neck as the animal shifted at his presence.

His fingers still trembled despite his efforts to steady them.

“Easy,” he murmured.

The horse tossed its head, breath steaming into the darkening air.

“I know.”

Nathanos reached for the rope securing it to the tree and worked the knot loose, then moved to the second horse and freed it in the same manner. With both animals still harnessed to the carrier, he checked the lines and fittings with practiced movements, making certain everything was properly secured before returning to the driver's bench.

He climbed into his seat and took the reins in both hands, the leather cold against his palms. It was a simple, familiar sensation, something solid enough to hold his attention when his thoughts threatened to return to the clearing, the bloodied armor or the face he alone had seen beneath the mask.

For a moment, he looked back toward the small window behind him.

Dim golden candlelight trembled through the frost-clouded glass, offering only the faintest glimpse of the place where Raphael lay within.

“Stay with me, Raphael,” Nathanos whispered.

Then he faced the road north.

The horses shifted beneath their harnesses as he drew in a cold breath and gently snapped the reins, urging them forward.

The carrier began to move.

Snow broke beneath its wheels, and the dark trees slowly parted as the narrow road opened before them, stretching northward through the winter forest toward Kalluth.

Nathanos tightened his grip upon the reins, holding to the knowledge that Raphael was still breathing behind him, and guided the horses onward.

“We are going home.”